

World in Brief: Trump's threats as first Iran talks conclude; hard-right candidate wins Colombian election



Photograph: Getty Images

American and **Iranian** officials concluded a round of talks in Switzerland over the next stage of their peace deal. Qatari and Pakistani mediators said there was “encouraging progress” made towards a lasting agreement. But Donald Trump warned that “I can do whatever I want” after a 60-day pause in fighting, including “take over the rest of the country”. Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, Iran’s lead negotiator, warned America against issuing threats.

Abelardo de la Espriella, a hard-right former criminal-defence lawyer, won the presidential run-off [election](#) in **Colombia**, according to an initial count. He took nearly 49.7% of the vote, compared with 48.7% for his left-wing rival Iván Cepeda. Mr de la Espriella has promised to smash gangs and drug traffickers, build mega-prisons in the jungle and shrink the state.

Britain’s prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, will reportedly announce his departure from office this week, perhaps as soon as Monday. Sir Keir has come under renewed pressure since Andy Burnham, the former mayor of Greater Manchester, [won a parliamentary by-election](#). That set up the prospect of a leadership

challenge, which Mr Burnham would almost certainly win. Sir Keir may prefer an orderly transfer of power.

Mr Trump weighed in on Sir Keir, posting that the prime minister “will resign” and had “failed badly” on immigration and energy. **America’s** president has been stirring trouble with other European leaders, too. He doubled down on claims that Giorgia Meloni begged him for a photo at a recent meeting. Italy’s prime minister firmly denied that, saying that Mr Trump should focus on his own popularity.

China imposed export controls on **MP Materials** and **USA Rare Earth**, two American **rare-earth** firms. Chinese companies will not be allowed to supply them with dual-use equipment that could be used for military, as well as commercial, purposes. Even non-Chinese firms will be barred from selling them kit that originated in China. China dominates the mining and processing of the minerals, used in everything from missiles to wind turbines.

Ethiopia’s prime minister, Abiy Ahmed, won a big victory in this month’s parliamentary elections. The National Election Board said his Prosperity Party took 438 out of 486 seats; in dozens of them it faced no opposition. During his **eight years in power**, Mr Ahmed has achieved rapid economic growth while overseeing a brutal civil war and **stoking tensions** with Ethiopia’s neighbours, particularly Eritrea.

Japan’s government said the fee for a tourist visa would quintuple from July. Entry into the country will now cost ¥15,000 (\$93), up from the current ¥3,000—the first rise since 1978. It comes at a time when Japanese are souring on tourists. This year scandals involving foreigners have encompassed everything from **sex tourism** to the alleged beating up of **a defenceless deer**.

Figure of the day: 3.3%, the percentage of straight American couples in which the woman is taller than the man, according to our

analysis of survey data. [Read why](#) short men continue to struggle in the dating market.

Israel out in the cold



Photograph: Getty Images

An official date has yet to be set for Israel's parliamentary election, but political insiders expect it to be October 20th. With four months to go, Binyamin Netanyahu is starting his re-election campaign at a low point.

Donald Trump's decision to sign a [memorandum of understanding with Iran](#) has damaged the prime minister's main selling points to the Israeli electorate. For decades he has made Israel's confrontation with Iran central to his agenda. Since 2016, when Mr Trump was first elected, he has also presented himself as having a unique partnership with America's president. Israel and America's joint decision to launch war against Iran in February seemed to prove the point.

Now this image looks tarnished. Mr Trump and his vice-president, J.D. Vance, have fiercely criticised Israel for not abiding by a [ceasefire in Lebanon](#). As America and Iran begin talks over the next stage of their deal, Israel can only look on in frustration.

Ukraine's strengths and vulnerabilities



Photograph: Reuters

The sight of columns of black smoke rising from an oil refinery in Moscow last week was testimony to the growing impact of [Ukraine's strike campaign](#). It showed how successfully the Ukrainians have depleted Russia's air defences even around the capital. Over the weekend officials in Russian-occupied Crimea also halted the sale of fuel at petrol stations because of Ukrainian drone attacks. On the ground, meanwhile, the picture is one of Russian pressure but minimal, if any, gains. One military analyst, Mick Ryan, describes the frontline as "a deep grey zone where control of ground changes rapidly and is continually contested".

Still, Russia can terrorise Ukrainian cities through its own aerial campaign. Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky, warned on Saturday of an impending "new massive strike". Its stockpile of Patriot interceptors is almost empty, leaving the country increasingly vulnerable to Russian ballistic-missile attacks.

A change of pace at China's central bank



Photograph: Alamy

China tends to do things in a rush. One exception is monetary policy. Unlike most central banks, which set an overnight interest rate, the People's Bank of China sets a rate for a leisurely seven days. It has also allowed market rates to drift quite far from this benchmark: as much as 0.5 percentage points above or 0.2 points below.

Last week, however, the central bank said it would henceforth run a tighter ship. The “corridor” within which rates can drift will narrow from 0.7 percentage points to 0.5. The bank will also pay more attention to overnight rates, a step toward shortening its policy rate. Its decisions filter through to longer-term commercial rates, like the loan-prime rate, a benchmark for mortgages, which was left unchanged on Monday. [China](#) is modernising its central banking. A week is a long time in politics, and in monetary policy, too.

The downside of Canada's oil windfall



Photograph: Reuters

On Monday Canada's inflation figures for May will show to what degree high energy costs have pumped up consumer prices. The Canadian economy has been behaving like a passenger jet flying on one engine. The bump in oil prices caused by the war in Iran has benefited oil-producing provinces in western Canada. But tepid business investment linked to Donald Trump's tariffs on steel, aluminium and Canadian-built cars has hobbled the eastern provinces and kept the economy from gaining altitude.

Economists expect Canada's annual inflation rate was around 3% last month, at the top of the Bank of Canada's target range of 1-3%. Still, the central bank is also weighing the risk that the economy could slow further, particularly amid uncertainty over the future of [Canada's trade pact with America and Mexico](#). Last week it decided to hold interest rates at 2.25%, but said that monetary policy would need to be "nimble".

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Those born between July 23 and August 22 are generally associated with which Zodiac sign?

Life did not intend to make us perfect. Whoever is perfect belongs in a museum.

Erich Maria Remarque